

A Call to the Global Fund Board to defend Gender Equality, Community Leadership and Human Rights in GC8. 54th Global Fund Board Meeting

Distinguished Members of the Board,

[Women4GlobalFund \(W4GF\)](#) is a global network of 433 advocates from 82 countries, mainly located in the Global South, dedicated to promoting gender equality and equity. W4GF ensures that Global Fund programmes are gender-responsive and transformative, addressing the specific needs of women and girls in all their diversity¹. We are committed to empowering women and girls, especially AGYW, by promoting their meaningful participation in decision-making processes at different levels and in international spaces, influencing policies and promoting accountability. W4GF envisions a world in which gender equity movements have transformed unequal power relations and privileges into equity and equality for all people.

As the Global Fund enters GC8, it does so amid shrinking allocations and despite enormous efforts, in a low-replenishment scenario, with new unified funding-request architecture, and an explicit emphasis on [transition, integration, and value for money](#). The Global Fund's [GC8 guidance](#) confirms that country allocations are predominantly reduced and that prioritization and transition pathways will increasingly shape what is funded and what is not. In this context, GC8 allocation decisions will determine life-or-death access to services for millions. [We have learnt key lessons from GC7 reprioritisation](#), acknowledging that gender, human rights and community components are crucial and we produced our manifesto of [what we cannot live without, from a feminist perspective](#).

[High-risk contexts](#) and [challenging Operating environments](#) where these decisions are already having profound consequences include Syria, Yemen, Sudan, Palestine, Sahel countries such as Mali and Burkina Faso, fragile settings in Ethiopia, Ukraine, Haiti, and crisis-affected contexts in Latin America and the Caribbean, including Venezuela. We are concerned about High Impact Portfolios, where Lenacapavir is starting implementation and where AGYW are at most risk. In MENA, conflict, displacement, criminalization, and shrinking civic space sharply restrict women's access to HIV, TB, and malaria services. In LAC, increasing violence, criminalisation, economic collapse, political exclusion, and migration are driving heightened vulnerability for transgender women, gender diversities, sex workers, and migrants.

We are increasingly concerned that Global Fund-supported programmes may face funding and implementation risks due to emerging restrictive policy shifts and new conditionalities linked to changes in donor funding frameworks. These shifts appear to be narrowing the space for gender equality, diversities, and comprehensive SRHR components—both at the Global Fund strategic level and within country-level implementation. In addition, evolving bilateral agreements between countries risk undermining integrated and rights-based responses for (AGYW), women, and gender-diverse communities, which are central to the Global Fund's mission and essential for effective, equitable, and sustainable health outcomes.

These realities are not peripheral; they are the real-world conditions GC8 must operate in and respond to. If GC8 proceeds without enforceable, funded protections for women and girls in all their diversity, including key populations, integration and transition risk becoming mechanisms of retrenchment: closing community spaces, cutting specialized services, and deepening inequities. The Global Fund's focus on prioritization and integration must be matched by **mandatory equity safeguards**, not voluntary commitments. The Global Fund must stay strong and rooted in the principles and the mission that has delivered impact and saved lives.

W4GF Strategic and Enforceable Recommendations

¹ W4GF focuses attention on women and girls in all of our diversity and our intersections, addressing issues faced by women living and/or affected by HIV, TB, and Malaria including heterosexual, lesbian, bisexual, intersex, non-binary, transgender women, sex workers over 18 years old, and adolescents, girls, and young women. We address challenges of indigenous, displaced, migrant, and refugee women; and women living with visible or non-visible disabilities.

1. Each funding request must include a standalone Community Annex that documents how women and girls in all their diversity, including key populations, have shaped priorities; identifies community-led services to be preserved; and presents a community-validated mitigation plan where services may change. Funding approval must be contingent on independent review of this annex.
2. TRP guidance and revisions must be central in all cases where community, gender and human rights programs and components are removed/ not included.
3. The Equity impact assessment should quantify and understand the equity implications of integration and transition processes, and the impact for women and girls in all their diversity, including key populations, particularly in relation to access, confidentiality, safety, and risk of exclusion. Funding releases for integrated proposals must be tied to acceptable assessment results and an agreed mitigation and implementation plans, with gender-transformative approaches, gender-assessments and stigma indexes.
4. A protected portion of each country allocation, or a pooled multicountry tranche, should be dedicated to:
 - (a) **sustaining community-led and peer-delivered services, especially in crisis and fragile settings;**
 - (b) **financing rapid continuity support during acute shocks, including mobile outreach and emergency support for peer workers; and**
 - (c) **resourcing community dialogues and community-led monitoring. Sustaining CCM budget lines to support engagement in each exercise. Making this window mandatory prevents critical services from being absorbed under integration pressures while incentivizing CCMs to design integrated programs that preserve community platforms and gender-transformation.**
5. As countries are encouraged to integrate services under GC8, the Global Fund must ensure that integration does not unintentionally reduce access, quality, safety and people-centred services for women and girls in all their diversity, including key populations. In many settings, particularly those affected by conflict, criminalization, or high stigma, rapid or under-resourced integration has resulted in the loss of trusted community-led services, breaches of confidentiality, and disengagement from care. Integration should therefore be phased and evidence-informed, proceeding only where it is demonstrated that services will remain accessible, confidential, and responsive.
6. Community-led monitoring, led by women-led organizations, must be financed, reported on a regular basis, linked to disbursement conditions, and inform Board-level oversight. LFAs and the Secretariat should verify monitoring outputs prior to tranche releases in high-risk contexts.

W4GF urges the Board to **establish red lines for GC8 approvals:**

- Specify Community Annex and EIA requirements in allocation letters and link final disbursements to independent clearance;
- Use LFAs and independent community review panels to vet annexes and assessments prior to grant signing;
- Operationalize the Crisis Continuity Window either as a mandatory 6–10% ring-fence per country allocation or as a guaranteed country tranche complemented by a pooled rapid-response facility;
- Integrate measurable gender equality indicators into grant performance frameworks; and
- Require mid-term continuity checks in conflict and fragile settings

The Global Fund was created to respond to the health crisis and not to retreat from them. GC8 allocations will define whether integration strengthens health systems while protecting equity and gender equality, or whether women's rights, community leadership, and gender-transformative programming become silent casualties of conflict and fiscal constraint. W4GF urges the Board to institutionalize community and women resilience now and stand ready to support the Global Fund in ensuring that GC88 protects lives and rights, and delivers lasting impact for women and girls in all their diversity.

W4GF respectfully urges the Board to safeguard the core mission and principles of the Global Fund, independently of external donor restrictions, and to remain firmly committed to evidence-based investments. Sustained financing for women and especially AGYW has consistently demonstrated high returns (RoI) and impact, and must remain central to delivering effective and equitable results.